billions of people. The industrial empires of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries exploited and repressed their colonies, and it would be foolhardy to expect the new digital empires to behave much better. Moreover, as noted earlier, if the world is divided into rival empires, humanity is unlikely to cooperate effectively to overcome the ecological crisis or to regulate AI and other disruptive technologies like bioengineering.

THE GLOBAL BOND

Of course, no matter whether the world is divided between a few digital empires, remains a more diverse community of two hundred nation-states or is split along altogether different and unforeseen lines, cooperation is always an option. Among humans, the precondition for cooperation isn't similarity; it is the ability to exchange information. As long as we are able to converse, we might find some shared story that can bring us closer. This, after all, is what made *Homo sapiens* the dominant species on the planet.

Just as different and even rival families can cooperate within a tribal network, and competing tribes can cooperate within a national network, so opposing nations and empires can cooperate within a global network. The stories that make such cooperation possible do not eliminate our differences; rather, they enable us to identify shared experiences and interests, which offer a common framework for thought and action.

A large part of what nevertheless makes global cooperation difficult is the misguided notion that it requires abolishing all cultural, social and political differences. Populist politicians often argue that if the international community agrees on a common story and on universal norms and values, this will destroy the independence and unique traditions of their own nation.[41] This position was unabashedly distilled in 2015 by Marine Le Pen – leader of France's National Front party – in an election speech in which she declared, 'We have entered a new two-partyism. A two-partyism between two mutually exclusive conceptions that will from now on structure our political life. The cleavage no longer separates left and right, but globalists and patriots.'[42] In August 2020, President Trump described his guiding ethos thus: 'We have rejected globalism and embraced patriotism.'[43]